



Are rival team fans a curse for home team sponsors? The moderating effects of fit, oppositional loyalty, and league sponsoring

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Abstract Sports sponsorship is big business, and a great deal of research provides evidence as to sponsorship’s efficacy in achieving a large range of communication goals, particularly for brands that are perceived as fitting well with the sport by the most involved fans. A developing body of literature, however, suggests that fan passion for a favorite team or athlete might work against the sponsors of hated rivals. The current research contributes to the rivalry effects topic by examining the impact of sponsor-sport fit, business rivalry, and league sponsoring on “home” team fan attitudes towards the sponsors of their team’s main rival. The study finds that negative rivalry effects are particularly severe when the rival team sponsor has high-perceived fit with the sport and is a direct business rival to a “home” team sponsor, but that league sponsorships largely mitigate these rivalry effects.

Keywords Sport sponsoring · League sponsoring · Rivalry effects · Fit
Oppositional loyalty

1 Introduction

With the placement of their brand logo on the fender of a race car, the cap of a golfer, or the jersey of a soccer team, sponsors can generally achieve communication goals most efficiently by targeting the most passionate sports fans who generally have higher sponsor recall/recognition and significantly more supportive attitudes and behavior regarding sponsors versus less involved spectators (Biscaia et al. 2013; Johar et al. 2006; Olson 2010; Olson and Thjomoe 2011a). These sponsorship enhancing fan passions are further heightened by the sight of their favorite team or athlete playing

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well against a hated rival (Herrmann et al. 2015; Zillman et al. 1989), but a growing body of literature finds that “home team” fan passions can also create negative feelings towards the sponsors of hated rivals (Bee and Dalakas 2015; Bergkvist 2012; Dalakas and Levin 2005; Hickman and Lawrence 2010). Although negative rivalry effects have been consistently found across several sponsorship contexts and explanatory theoretical frameworks, the current research contributes to the area by testing the potential moderating influence of sponsor-sport fit, oppositional loyalty, and league sponsoring.

High sponsor-sport fit (a.k.a. congruence or relatedness) is typically defined as the perception that a brand’s association with the sponsored entity (e.g., team/athlete/event) “makes sense” and has generally been found to enhance attitudes towards the sponsor by creating a stronger link between the positive associations/feelings held for the sponsored entity and the sponsoring brand(s) (Olson and Thjomoe 2011b). Therefore, research question (RQ) 1 asks:

RQ1: Are the derogatory attitudes held by home team fans towards rival team sponsors moderated (exacerbated) by higher sponsor-sport fit?

Active participation in a brand community has been found to bring about oppositional loyalty, which includes negative attitudes towards rival brands and non-adoption of rival brand products (Thompson and Sinha 2008). In a sports team context, each team’s fans can be viewed as individual brand communities, and RQ2 addresses whether oppositional loyalty is more severe when a rival team’s sponsor is a business rival to a home team sponsor, and whether this oppositional loyalty might be further exacerbated in high sponsor-sport fit conditions.

RQ2: Is oppositional loyalty higher when rival team sponsors are direct business competitors with home team sponsors, and is this oppositional loyalty moderated (exacerbated) by high levels of sponsor-sport fit?

League sponsors should not be primarily associated with any particular rival team, and RQ3 addresses the previously untested suggestion that league sponsoring might therefore mitigate negative rivalry effects (Bergkvist 2012) and also reduce oppositional loyalty in situations where a league sponsor competes with a home team sponsor.

RQ3: Does league sponsoring significantly reduce negative rivalry effects and oppositional loyalty?

These research questions are addressed using an experiment involving professional football fans, where the overall results show that better sponsor-sport fit increases negative rivalry effects, particularly when the rival team sponsor is a business competitor to a home team sponsor, but that these negative rivalry effects are largely mitigated by league sponsoring.

2 Method

The highly successful English Premier League team Manchester United Football Club (MU) is utilized as the home team. Manchester City (MC) is used as the rival team due

to their runner-up finish to MU in the 2013 Premier League final, and because MC has been named MU's biggest rival by the MU manager (Jackson 2012). Based on pre-tests and a review of the business rivalry literature, sports drink brands and IT brands are utilized for the high-fit and low-fit conditions, respectively. Gatorade and Powerade are chosen for the sports drink brands because of their long time competition for worldwide market share (Statista 2015), and pre-tests showed no significant attitudinal differences using the Olson (2010) sponsor attitude scale. To further enhance fit perceptions, respondents were told that team players would be drinking the sponsoring sports drink for improved game performance (Olson and Thjomoe 2011b). Oracle and SAP represent the low-fit IT brand sponsors due to their history of business competition and sport sponsorships (Ricadela 2012) and equality in pre-test attitudes. None of these stimuli brands are current or previous sponsors of any English Premier League team.

Using Internet and social media sites dedicated to MU, fans were recruited via open invitations to participate in an online survey regarding the team, and the 302 respondents were randomly assigned to one of the eight experimental and two control groups (group $n = 30$ or 31). The age distribution of the sample is representative of the young adult male segment often targeted by sports sponsors (Loechner 2009), with 96% falling between the ages of 18 and 34 ($M = 26.1$ years) and 86% male. Data was collected before the end of the 2013 Premier League season to coincide with the timeframe that is normally used for new sponsorship announcements, but before any actual team announcements were made regarding sponsorships for the coming season.

In a similar fashion to previous sponsorship research (e.g., Olson and Thjomoe 2011b), fictional press releases of approximately 350 words provided respondents with information about next season's league and team sponsors corresponding with the necessary manipulations. The press releases reported Gatorade or SAP as next season's MU sponsors and Powerade or Oracle as the MC or Premier League sponsors.¹ To disguise the focus of the study, new sponsor announcements by two other Premier League teams were utilized as filler and reported in each press release. To address RQ2 and RQ3, press releases incorporated an added sentence stating that business analysts also noted the new (MC or Premier League) sponsor (Powerade or Oracle) is a fierce global competitor to new MU sponsor (Gatorade or SAP). For both high- and low-fit sponsors, the press releases claimed that the sponsors were excited to become a part of the respective team or Premier League family and to provide funding that would help strengthen the squad or league.

After exposure to the press release, respondents were asked to answer 3-item scales measuring sponsor-sport fit and rival team sponsoring brand attitude (Oracle or Powerade) (Olson 2010), a 7-item Sport Spectator Identification scale (Wann and Branscombe 1993), and demographic questions. Upon completion respondents were thanked and informed that the press release was fictional, while respondents assigned to control groups were not exposed to any press release, but were given the same fit and attitude measures regarding Oracle or Powerade plus three filler brands. Cronbach alpha was .88 for the Sport Identification scale and .928 or higher for the fit and attitude measures of each brand, allowing the

¹ To confirm the pre-test results showing no significant attitudinal differences between the test brands, data was also collected with press releases that reversed the sponsoring brands (i.e., Gatorade and SAP as rival sponsors), and no significant differences were found in the results. Thus, for reasons of parsimony, only the Powerade and Oracle as rival sponsor results are reported, but details on the reversed brand data results are available upon request.

creation of overall fit and attitude indices for analysis and results reporting. Group comparisons reveal no significant demographic differences between the groups and uniformly high identification with MU ($M = 5.8/7$), while the significantly higher sponsor-sport fit mean for the sports drink ($M = 5.4$) versus the IT brand ($M = 1.6$) conditions confirm the fit manipulation (t value = 85.4, $p < .000$). Research questions are addressed using hierarchical multiple regression featuring a single two level predictor variable, a two level moderator main effects variable, and a moderator interaction term comprised of the predictor * moderator main effect variable (Jaccard and Turrissi 2003), with all manipulations involving comparisons of the same brand (Powerade or Oracle) across the control group and rival team/league sponsor conditions.

3 Results

RQ1 is addressed using overall brand attitude (OVATT) as the dependent variable, rival sponsor (RIVSP) as the dummy predictor variable, overall sponsor-sport fit (FIT) as the moderator main effect predictor, and the moderator interaction = RIVSP * FIT. Table 1 presents the regression results for RQ1 and shows that rival team (MC) sponsorship is a significant negative predictor of OVATT at all regression hierarchy levels, while the inclusion of the FIT moderator has a significant positive main effect ($p < .01$), and the negative interaction term is marginally significant ($p < .1$). Figure 1 displays the brand attitudes of the comparison group relative to the control group (RELATT = control group means of 4.49 for Powerade and 3.85 for Oracle are subtracted from respective overall brand attitude as rival team sponsor, and therefore, a value of zero indicates the experimental group brand attitude is equal to the control group for the same brand), and the results show significantly lower attitudes for both the low-fit (-0.7) and high-fit (-1.2) brands when they sponsor rival teams ($p < .000$). The finding that RIVSP reduces home team fan brand attitudes is therefore consistent with earlier rivalry effects research, while the significant RIVSP * FIT interaction extends past research by showing that high-fit rival team sponsors experience even more negative rivalry effects than less fitting brands.

RQ2 asks whether oppositional loyalty will be higher towards home team sponsor rivals (HTSR) and if this relationship will be moderated (exacerbated) by higher FIT. The dependent variable is relative to control group brand attitude (RELATT), which allows for the rivalry effect to be isolated from the overall influence of the predictor and moderator variables. The predictor variable is HTSR (1 = rival team sponsor is business competitor to home team sponsor, 0 = rival team sponsor is not a business competitor to home team sponsor), the moderator main effect predictor is FIT, and the moderator interaction is HTSR * FIT. Table 1 regression results show that HTSR is a significant negative predictor of RELATT (i.e., widens the brand attitude deficit versus the control group mean), while the main effect of the FIT moderator is also significantly negative ($p < .00$) and the interaction term is significantly negative and greatly moderates the impact of HTSR, eliminating its significance as a predictor of RELATT. Figure 1 visually demonstrates the RELATT means for the two RQ2 experimental groups, showing the RELATT gaps for both high-fit and low-fit brands becoming significantly wider in the HTSR = 1 condition versus the HTSR = 0 (Oracle = -1.2 vs. -0.7 , $p < .02$; Powerade = -2.2 vs. -1.2 , $p < .00$). The significant interaction effect is demonstrated by the significantly wider gap between the low-fit (-0.5) to high-fit (-1.0) brands in the HTSR = 1 condition versus the gap in the HTSR = 0 conditions ($p < .03$).

Table 1 Hierarchical regression results

Research Question & Hierarchy Level	Dep. Variable	Predictor Variable	Moderator Main Effect Variable	Moderator Interaction Term	Adj. Rsqr
		Coeff.	Coeff.(sig)	Coeff.(sig)	Coeff.(sig)
RQ1		Constant	RIVSP	FIT	RIVSP*FIT
1	Overall Attitude (OVATT)	4.17	-0.97 (.000)		0.263
2		3.80	-0.98 (.000)	0.11 (.002)	0.304
3		3.61	-0.59 (.025)	0.17 (.002)	-0.12 (.065)
		Constant	HTSR	FIT	HTSR*FIT
RQ2					
1	Relative Attitude (RELATT)	0.97	0.69 (.000)		0.119
2		0.32	0.70 (.000)	0.19 (.000)	0.247
3		0.56	.23 (.236)	0.19 (.022)	0.14 (.049)
		Constant	LGSP	HTSR	LGSP*HTSR
RQ3					
1	Relative Attitude (RELATT)	1.32	-1.44 (.000)		0.410
2		1.03	-1.44 (.000)	0.58 (.000)	0.475
3		0.97	-1.33 (.000)	0.69 (.000)	-0.22 (.124)

Notes on variables: OVATT = overall attitude towards sponsor. RELATT = (OVATT – same brand control group mean). Rival Sponsor (RIVSP) is dummy with 1 = yes brand is sponsor of rival team and 0 = no (control group). Home Team Sponsor Rival (HTSR) is dummy with 1 = rival team sponsor is business competitor with home team sponsor and 0 = rival team sponsor is not a business competitor to home team sponsor. League sponsor (LGSP) is dummy where 1 = league sponsor and 0 = rival team sponsor. Attitude (positive, like, purchase intention) & Fit (logical connection, similar, makes sense) scales from Olson (2010).

Notes on variables: OVATT overall attitude towards sponsor. RELATT = (OVATT—same brand control group mean). Rival sponsor (RIVSP) is dummy with 1 = yes brand is sponsor of rival team and 0 = no (control group). Home team sponsor rival (HTSR) is dummy with 1 = rival team sponsor is business competitor with home team sponsor and 0 = rival team sponsor is not a business competitor to home team sponsor. League sponsor (LGSP) is dummy where 1 = league sponsor and 0 = rival team sponsor. Attitude (positive, like, purchase intention) and Fit (logical connection, similar, makes sense) scales from Olson (2010)

RELATT is also used for RQ3's examination of league sponsoring as a potential means of reducing the negative effects experienced by rival team sponsors and if these effects will be moderated (reduced) in the HTSR condition. The dummy predictor variable is league sponsorship (LGSP where 1 = Premier League sponsor or 0 = MC team sponsor), while the moderator is HTSR and the interaction term is LGSP * HTSR. The regression results in Table 1 show that LGSP is a significant positive predictor of RELATT (i.e., improves brand attitude vs. the control group). The inclusion of the HTSR moderator provides a significant negative main effect (i.e., decreases the league sponsoring brand attitude advantage vs. the control group), but the positive interaction term is not a significant moderator. The lack of a significant interaction effect suggests that league sponsors that are also business rivals to home team sponsors do not benefit from significantly less oppositional loyalty effects versus the same brand as a rival team sponsor. Figure 2 visually demonstrates the RQ3 results by comparing LGSP versus RIVSP conditions and shows that RELATT is significantly better for league sponsors, although only the league sponsorship with the HTSR = 0 condition actually surpasses the control group brand attitude as indicated by the significantly higher than control group 0.36 mean ($t = 2.89, p < .005$). Figure 2 also illustrates the insignificant interaction term as the gap between HTSR = 1 and HTSR = 0 conditions changes relatively little between the LGSP = 1 and LGSP = 0 cells (.47 vs .69, $t = 1.35, p = .179$). Although not shown in Table 1 or Fig. 2, the RQ3 results also hold true for both the high-fit and low-fit brands when they are analyzed separately.

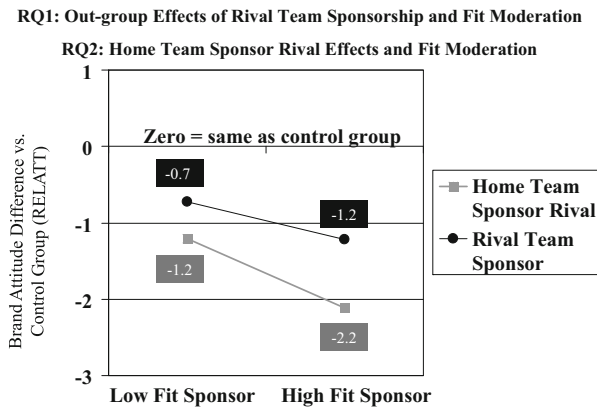


Fig. 1 RQ1: Out-group effects of rival team sponsorship and fit moderation. RQ2: Home team sponsor rival effects and fit moderation. Result notes: RQ1 finds sponsorship of rival team results in significantly lower brand attitudes versus the control group means = 4.5 for high fit and 3.9 for low fit (high fit = -1.2 , t value 6.19; low fit = -0.7 , t value 3.56, $p = .000$). RQ2 finds rival team sponsors that are also business rivals to home team sponsors have significantly lower RELATT than same brands as only rival team sponsors (high fit t value 4.54, $p = .000$; low fit t value 2.05, $p = .022$), and this gap widens in high-fit (1.0) versus low-fit (0.5) conditions (t value 1.96, $p = .028$). As noted in footnote 1, results above use Powerade and Oracle as rival team sponsors, but RQ1 and RQ2 results are unchanged statistically and virtually identical nominally when Gatorade and SAP are used as rival team sponsors; thus, brand strength variance cannot be alternative explanation for the results

4 Discussion and conclusion

Contrary to most sponsorship literature that finds positive sponsorship effects among the passionate fans of a sports entity sponsored by a good fitting brand, the RQ1 results show that fan love for their favorite sports entity and its sponsors turns to increasing hatred for better fitting rival entity sponsors. The RQ2 results suggest that home team fans are likely to be even more negative towards rival team sponsors when they are

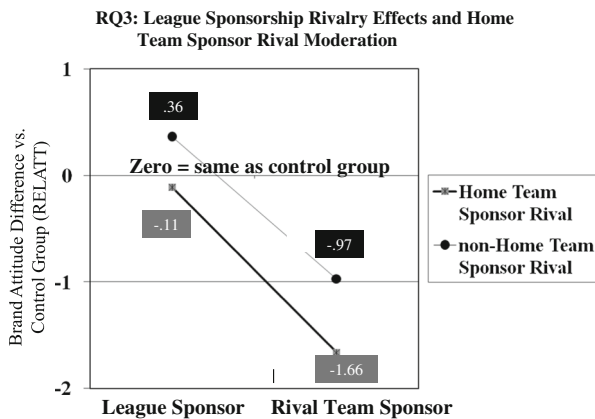


Fig. 2 RQ3: League sponsorship rivalry effects and home team sponsor rival moderation. Result note: RQ3 finds league sponsoring has significantly higher relative attitude versus same brands as rival team sponsors (.36 vs. $-.97$, $t = 8.88$, $p < .000$), but league sponsorship does not significantly shrink oppositional loyalty gap when the league sponsor competes with home team sponsor versus same brand as rival team sponsor competing with home team sponsor (.47 vs. .69, $t = 1.35$, $p = .179$)

business competitors with home team sponsors, particularly when the sponsor is perceived as fitting well with the sport. The RQ3 results find league sponsorship eliminates negative rivalry effects as long as the sponsor is not a business competitor to a home team sponsor.

The similarity of the current results with earlier research suggests that negative rivalry effects are robust across differing contexts, theoretical frameworks, and methodologies. Furthermore, the overall results suggest that brand managers hoping to maximize their sponsoring effectiveness by targeting the passionate fans of a particular entity also need to calculate their net sponsorship payoff by subtracting the possible negative reaction of rival team fans, particularly in cases involving brands that fit well with a particular sports entity and/or when a direct business competitor is a rival entity sponsor. These net sponsorship effect calculations will therefore need to consider the relative size of “home” and “rival” fan-bases, which may make popular teams such as Manchester United even more attractive since “loving” home team fans are more likely to outnumber “hating” rival team fans. The RQ3 results indicate that league sponsors should use “exclusivity” clauses in their sponsorship contracts to ensure that business competitors cannot create oppositional loyalty losses by sponsoring individual league teams.

The results also suggest some areas for future research, such as replicating the relationships tested here in contexts involving the sponsors of individual athletes in non-team sports such as golf, or extending the current findings by testing rivalry effects in contexts involving sponsored entities that are perceived as weaker rivals to the fan’s favorite sports entity. Future research might also address whether negative rivalry effects are reduced by matching target market coverage with team fan-base coverage, such as when national brands sponsor national teams and regional brands sponsor teams with similar geographic fan-base coverage. Future research could also examine whether the US professional and university team sports model, which tends to emphasize league sponsors and/or generally limits sponsor logo placement on team uniforms, is effective in reducing negative rivalry effects relative to sports contexts that provide prominent placement of team sponsor logos on team uniforms and equipment (Olson and Thjomoe 2009). Another possible avenue for reducing negative rivalry effects when targeting sports fans might come from linking sponsor logos with less competition focused entities such league/sport-based exhibits or museums and/or charity/special cause supporting events such as the Special Olympics and youth tournaments, although future research should investigate whether the sponsorship of less competition focused sports entities also reduces net sponsoring effectiveness by lessening the positive impact of fan passions.

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